Earl Hickson Jr.

HCI Graduate Applicant | Lead Front-End Engineer

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APPLICANT SUMMARY

Front-end engineer and independent HCI practitioner with a background in graphic design, frontend engineering, and full-stack product development. My work explores how interactive systems can strengthen human capability across relationships, learning, privacy, and complex decision-making without unnecessarily replacing human agency.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Human-computer interaction | Learning technologies | Privacy and consent | Decision support | Information architecture | Accessibility | Human agency and automation

EDUCATION AND CERTIFICATIONS

Bachelor of Fine Arts in Graphic Design | Kean University, Union, New Jersey | 2015

IBM Full Stack Software Developer Professional Certificate | IBM / Coursera | December 2025 | Verify

Full Stack JavaScript Certificate | Team Treehouse | 2022

Front-End Web Development Certificate | Team Treehouse | 2022

SELECTED INDEPENDENT HCI INVESTIGATIONS

WithYou | Independent HCI investigation

How should shared technology support connection without assuming unrestricted access?

Contribution: Solo product design, UX engineering, and full-stack development. Evidence boundary: Legacy profile visibility is per account, not per relationship space.

ehicksonjr.com/work/withyou

Gundam Forge | Independent HCI investigation

How can interfaces help people navigate complexity without making the decision for them?

Contribution: Solo product design and full-stack product development. Evidence boundary: Official competitive ban/restriction coverage is incomplete.

ehicksonjr.com/work/gundam-forge

DojoNet | Independent HCI investigation

How can digital systems support progression without reducing learning to completion?

Contribution: Solo product design and frontend product development. Evidence boundary: Instructor workflows require further design and implementation verification.

ehicksonjr.com/work/dojonet

TECHNICAL PREPARATION

Production (employer and client work): JavaScript (ES6+), HTML5, CSS3, SCSS/Sass, React, Vue.js, Bootstrap 3-5, REST APIs (GET/POST, JSON), Responsive and mobile-first UI, WCAG 2.1 AA, Cross-browser QA, Git, Bitbucket, CI/CD pipelines, .NET-hosted front ends, WordPress (custom PHP plugins), Wix CMS, Responsive HTML email

Shipped in independent products: TypeScript, Next.js (App Router, static export), Tailwind CSS, Vitest, React Testing Library, Zod, TanStack Query, Radix UI, Zustand, Node.js, Express, Prisma, PostgreSQL, Supabase, React Native (Expo), Socket.IO, GitHub Actions, Playwright, Vite

Design and UX: Figma, Adobe Creative Suite (Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign), Design tokens and component standards, Information architecture, Interaction design, Design-to-code handoff

Measurement and platforms: Google Analytics, Hotjar, Lighthouse, SEO, HubSpot, Salesforce Marketing Cloud, Zen Planner API

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Front-End Developer & Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu Professor | AMA Fight Club

Cedar Knolls, NJ | Jan 2025 - Present

Own the gym's website end to end, including a Zen Planner API integration that syncs web leads to the membership CRM, and lead its Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu program.

Independent Front-End Developer | Freelance and Contract

Remote | Nov 2024 - Oct 2025

A custom WordPress donation-campaign plugin for Tabby's Place, and React and TypeScript dashboard screens for Wealth Creation Innovation.

Front-End Developer | Asembia

Florham Park, NJ | Dec 2023 - Oct 2024

Set one component and brand-token standard across HIPAA-regulated patient, provider, and prescriber portals, led the Bootstrap 3 to 5 migration, and got the team building to it.

Lead Designer & Front-End Developer | BroadcastMed / Conexiant

Remote | Aug 2021 - Feb 2023

Led design and front-end delivery of healthcare marketing microsites, raised lead-form submissions 18%, and built an email system that cut production time 25%.

Front-End Developer, Contract | Prosek Partners

Remote | Apr 2021 - Sep 2021

Responsive landing pages and campaign interfaces in React, plus client projects in Vue.js.

Front-End Developer, Contract | William R. Seide Agency LLC

New Jersey | Jan 2020 - Jun 2020

Mobile-first sites for insurance and financial-services clients.

Email Marketing Specialist, Contract | Merkle

Remote | Nov 2018 - Jul 2019

Responsive HTML email for pharmaceutical campaigns, tested across email clients.

Earlier: front-end and digital design roles at Kirshenbaum Bond Senecal + Partners and Second Melody, 2013-2017.

COACHING AND LEADERSHIP

A Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu black belt, teaching youth and adult students since 2021. That coaching carries straight into mentoring engineers: progressive instruction, close observation, honest feedback, and adapting to how each person learns.

AMA Fight Club | Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu Professor | Cedar Knolls, NJ | 2025 - Present

Colton Brown Training Center | Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu Instructor | Warren, NJ | 2023 - 2024

Pure MMA | Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu Instructor | Rockaway, NJ | 2021 - 2022

RESEARCH PREPARATION

Methods used: Analytics review | Hotjar-informed evaluation | Accessibility auditing | Interaction prototyping | Design-system evaluation | Implementation analysis | Technical usability review

Methods sought through graduate study: Semi-structured interviews | Usability testing | Diary studies | Contextual inquiry | Observation | Qualitative coding | Experimental design | Mixed methods | Research ethics

SELECTED WRITING

Teaching Jiu-Jitsu Changed the Way I Think About UX | Learning | July 14, 2026

Designing Consent Into Digital Products | Relationships | July 14, 2026

What Trading Card Games Teach Us About Information Architecture | Decision Support | July 14, 2026